PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

The Enforcement Acts — A House Divided

When Washington Chose to Act

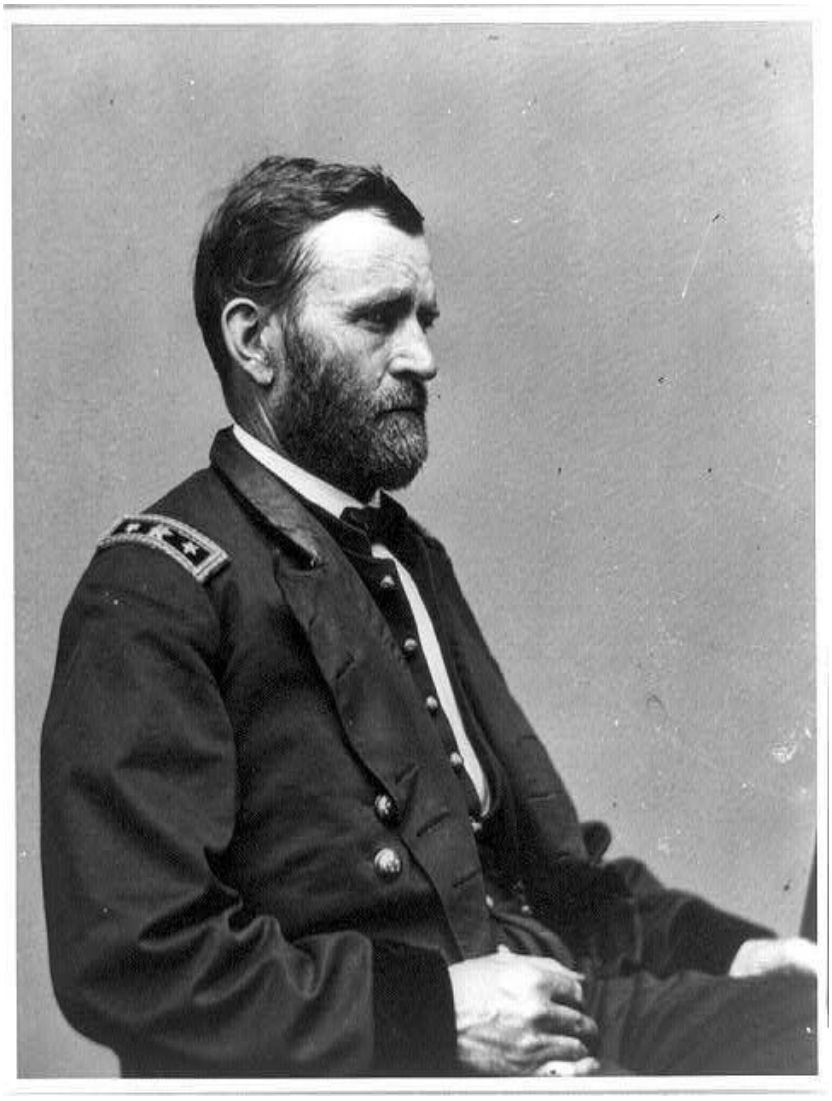
Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about The Enforcement Acts — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. One decision produced real results. Trace the causes, the effects — and what the story depends on

THE SOURCES

THE IMAGE — President Ulysses S. Grant



President Ulysses S. Grant — photograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE · WHAT THE ENFORCEMENT ACTS DID — Federal power against terror

> *The Enforcement Acts (1870–71), including the Ku Klux Klan Act, made it a federal crime to conspire to deny citizens their rights; let the president use troops and suspend habeas corpus; and led to hundreds of prosecutions. By 1872 the Klan was largely broken and Black voting rebounded.*
> *— summarized from the historical record. Public domain*

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YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · THE CAUSE

The amendments already guaranteed Black rights. Why were the Enforcement Acts still necessary?

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · THE EFFECT

What was the main effect of Grant's aggressive use of the Enforcement Acts by 1872?

- ☐ A. the Klan grew stronger
- ☐ B. the Klan was largely broken and Black voting rebounded
- ☐ C. nothing changed
- ☐ D. the amendments were repealed

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · THE BIG IDEA

The success of the Enforcement Acts proved something important about protecting rights. In your own words, what did it prove — and why is that both hopeful and troubling?

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · THE WARNING

If rights were protected only because the federal government chose to act, what would happen when it stopped choosing to act? In three or four sentences, predict the consequence — and connect it to what you know comes next in Reconstruction.

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — The Enforcement Acts — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "The rights existed on paper, but..., so the Acts were needed to..."

QUESTION 2: **Correct — B. the Klan was largely broken and Black voting rebounded**

Right. Federal prosecutions and troops largely broke the Klan, and Black Southerners were able to vote again in large numbers — proof that federal power could protect rights.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "It proved that...; this is hopeful because..., but troubling because..."

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "If the government stopped enforcing rights, then..."